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Change control

Learning objective:

24. Understand change control as the ability to manage variations and change requests in a controlled way.



24a) Understand the purpose and importance of each stage of a typical change control process (such as request, initial evaluation, detailed evaluation, recommendation, update plans and implement) and understand where these stages are different for linear and iterative life cycles.

Purpose and importance of change control for linear and iterative life cycles

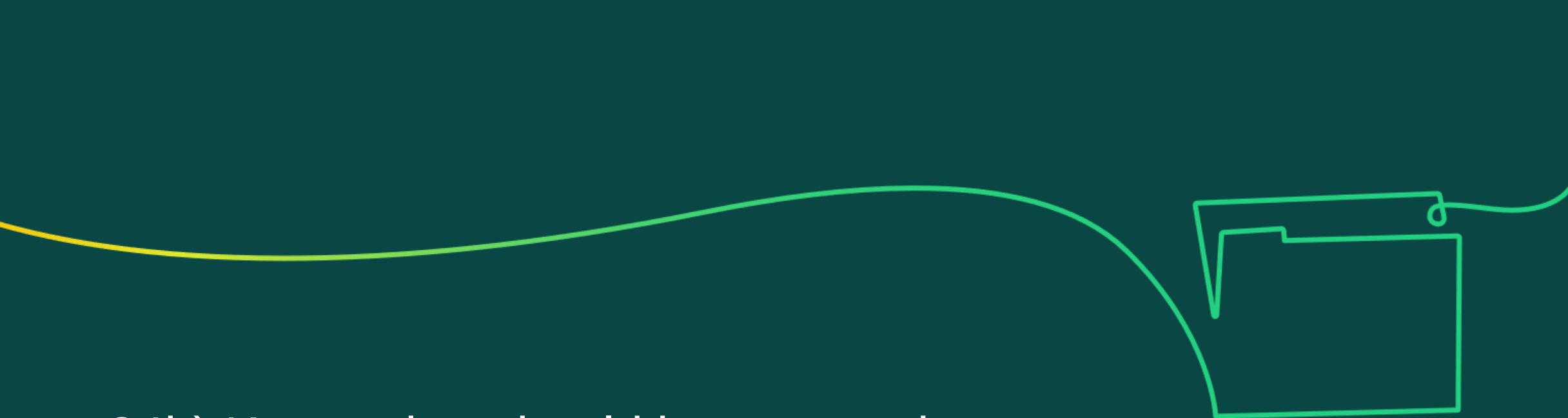
Change control manages all requests to change the baseline of a project. These requests can come from different sources for different reasons. Once identified, they need to be evaluated and either approved, rejected or deferred.

- Managing change requests in a structured way enables the project sponsor and stakeholders to understand the impact on the outcomes of baselined work and influence the decision on how to respond, considering objectives and risk appetite.
- The consequence of unmanaged change can be far-reaching within the project environment and to business-as-usual activities.
- In some situations, a change freeze may be needed. This prevents any further change be considered in the project, to protect delivery of the objective.
- Projects using an iterative life cycle embed change control as part of the development process, starting each iteration with a planning meeting that clarifies the goals and items to be delivered.
- In iterative life cycles, change is much more normal and expected, rather than needing an exceptional meeting or process to resolve (though change requests can still be raised if required). Changes to existing features or the goals and/or items in that iteration can be considered alongside the existing requirements.

Stages of a typical change control process

- **Request:** Change requests (CRs) can be made by internal or external stakeholders, documenting relevant information on the nature of the change and reasoning for it. The request should be logged in the change register, given a unique identifier and assigned an owner to evaluate.
- **Initial evaluation:** The owner decides whether the change should be evaluated in detail or rejected at this stage, looking to determine its necessity, feasibility, potential impact on the project and the rationale for raising.
- **Detailed evaluation:** The owner considers the impacts on the project baseline success criteria and on work already completed. Other projects and business as usual should also be considered.
- **Recommendation and decision:** The results of the evaluation are presented to the sponsor and/or wider governance board for a decision. The options are defer (further clarification or information needed), reject (cost or risk of the change exceed the value the change will bring or go beyond agreed thresholds), or approve (the value being created from the change is worth the cost of implementing).
- **Update plans and implement:** The status of the change request is updated in the change log. The sponsor makes sure the decision is communicated. If the change is approved, baselined plans and budgets are updated, including the business case if required, and any new risks raised are added to the risk register. Actions are implemented in line with the revised plan and monitored through to completion. Configuration records are updated to reflect the latest version of project documents incorporating the change.
- **Communicate change:** All updated roles and responsibilities, documentation and plans are communicated to stakeholders.





24b) Know what should be captured and recorded in change requests.

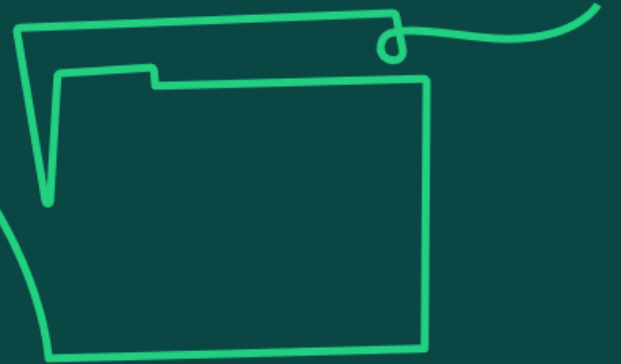


A typical change request

Typical information captured in a change request form, to support project evaluations and a decision being made, includes:

- project overview
- description covering the nature of what the change is
- reason for the change
- areas impacted
- source of change
- change request owner
- date raised and unique identifier
- status of the change request
- decision, date made and justification

24c) Know ways to assess options related to a proposed change and the high-level impact of the proposed change.



Assessing the options

What's feasible?

- Options are assessed against the impact they have on achieving the success criteria set out in the business case, and whether the skills and resources needed to deliver the change are available.
- A change may impact any of the following:
 - benefits
 - scope
 - schedules
 - costs
 - quality
 - resources
 - risks
 - stakeholders
- Understanding why the change has been raised is also important when assessing options – is it mandatory, a change in regulation, risk profile, customer needs or financial constraints driving the request?
- Another consideration is the resources required to undertake the assessment. Before evaluating, the project should consider whether to assess such a change at all.

Assessing the options

Assessing High-Level Impact of the Proposed Change

- Understanding the broader implications of a proposed change is crucial for maintaining alignment with the project's goals and the strategic objectives of the organisation.
- *The following are the steps to assess the high-level impact of the proposed change:*
 1. **Project Scope:** Determine whether the proposed change will expand, reduce, or alter the deliverables of the project, potentially affecting project goals. Consider the implications for project complexity and whether additional adjustments will be required in other areas of the project.
 2. **Project Schedule:** Evaluate the potential for the proposed change to delay critical milestones or possibly expedite certain phases of the project. Assess the flexibility of the project schedule to accommodate the change, considering the impact on overall project delivery and deadlines.
 3. **Resource Allocation:** Examine whether the change will necessitate additional resources or redistribute existing ones, potentially impacting other project areas. Consider the availability of required resources and the feasibility of reallocating them without disrupting other operations.

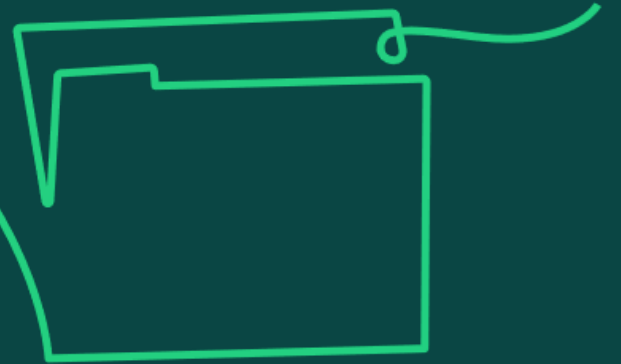
Assessing the options

Assessing High-Level Impact of the Proposed Change

4. **Quality of Output:** Assess how the change will affect the overall quality of project deliverables, potentially enhancing or diminishing the value provided to stakeholders. Consider the impact on project standards and compliance requirements, ensuring that quality benchmarks are still met.
5. **Compliance and Regulatory Issues:** Investigate any legal or regulatory impacts due to the change, ensuring continued compliance with relevant standards and laws. Consider the need for additional approvals or oversight, potentially affecting project timelines and costs.
6. **Long-Term Strategic Impact:** Evaluate how the change aligns with the strategic goals of the organisation, considering its contribution to long-term objectives. Consider potential market and competitive impacts, ensuring that the change supports sustained organisational growth and adaptation.

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24d) Understand how to justify recommendations about whether to approve, reject or defer changes.



How to justify recommendations

A recommendation is driven from the evaluation that looks at whether the proposed change could jeopardise the achievement of the project objectives.

Some points to consider when justifying the recommendation include:

- What areas of the project will be affected? How will they be affected? Does the project have the skills and resources needed to handle it?
- Does the project have sufficient budget in the contingency budget to draw down or would further funding be needed?
- If additional resources are needed, does the business have the capacity and the capability to source them? Would external (to the project) help be needed?
- Can the project maintain delivery on time? If not, will the project outcomes still be of use to the business?
- Are the benefits listed in the business case going to be materially impacted in any way? If so, how and what does that mean both for the project and the business?



24e) Understand the importance of updating plans and schedules to reflect and communicate changes.

Updating plans and schedules

- Poorly managed change is still one of the most common reasons why projects fail. Managing requests for change effectively is a proven success factor for project delivery.
- The project management plan sets out what is expected from the project team. If this is not updated and communicated when changes are made, the team will be working from outdated information, costing the project time and money.
- This can cause unnecessary conflict among the team about what needs to be delivered, impacting team performance and satisfaction levels.
- The solution could end up redundant if what is delivered is not fit for purpose or not delivered in time.
- Stakeholders could disengage through the loss in confidence of the project team's ability to deliver the project's outcomes to the agreed success criteria.
- This could have a knock-on impact on other change activity happening in the business or on business as usual.
- Ultimately, the benefits in the business case may not be realised, impacting the return-on-investment.